

Glossary

Reverb: This allows you to recreate the space that is sometimes lost with close-mike recording techniques. It may also be used to create effects by placing sounds in spaces where they would normally never be heard. Reverb consists of early reflections, which are the first reflections that arrive back to your ear and the echoes themselves.

Flange: Also popularly known as Wah-Wah, this is used to create the sweeping effect often heard in guitar recordings from the 1960s and in the techno sounds of today. Using this effect, you can recreate the sounds that flange, i.e. move in a sweeping manner.

Multi-tap delay: This allows you to create complex delay patterns through the use of several discrete delays. Each delay tap has its own delay time, amplitude, and stereo panning controls.

Resample: Resampling data changes the number of recorded samples per second. When changing to a higher sample rate, extra samples are interpolated and the file size increases. When changing to a lower sample rate, some samples are removed and the file size decreases.

Acoustic mirror: You can use Acoustic Mirror to add the acoustical coloration of real environments and sound-altering devices to existing recordings. In effect, you can simulate responses varying from the acoustics of large concert halls to the sound of vintage microphones.

Distortion: This allows you to precisely tailor gain at all input levels of a signal. You can use the Distortion plugin to create dramatic to subtle distortion, simple compression, expansion, and noise gates.

ease of use. Some wave editing software offer you a very visual interface. They provide tools such as 2D and 3D analysis, colour-coded windows, etc, which add a lot to the term 'ease of use'.

Considering ease of use, most of the software we tested offer a simple interface and enhancements that make working with the software easier. Editing with Cool Edit 2000 is a breeze. You can easily cut and paste parts of your song and add a particular effect. Cool Edit lets you cue your songs so that only specified parts are played. This is especially useful if you are going to be adding a vocal track to your song and need only certain parts to be played at given times.

The interface of Sound Forge looks clean and concise and can be easily customised to suit your needs so that you can work faster. The time taken for applying an effect is displayed at the bottom of the screen. If you accidentally switch off the machine or experience a power failure, Sound Forge can restore the file to the previous state without losing any change.

Installing WaveFlow was quick and easy and the graphical interface makes editing quite simple. So, even if you are using the software for the first time, understanding and working with it will be no difficult task. Besides, you have the option of opening multiple windows, and this allows you to get your work done faster.

Goldwave is where you can have user-defined filters and you can even save it for future use. Editing using Goldwave is simple enough even if you are working on audio editing for the first time. The MDI (multiple document interface) allows you to open a number of files at the same time. However, there's no multiple Undo feature, which is a major limitation.

Although the more feature-packed software such as Cool Edit 2000 and Sound Forge 5 make editing a cakewalk, Goldwave with its multiple-window support, is an option that can be considered.

Performance

Though audio editing software depend heavily on RAM and the CPU more than anything else, it helps if the software performs tasks such as encoding audio and adding effects faster with lesser amount of RAM. To test the performance of the software, we re-sampled a 51 MB wave file and the time taken was noted down. Normally when an effect is applied to a file, it takes a lot of time for the effect to be applied if the size of the file is large (say 50 MB). Now if a user wants to remove the previous effect and add a different one, it gets really painful if the software does not have an Undo feature or if it undoes only up to a couple of levels. A good audio editing soft-

ware should support the Undo feature up to maximum levels possible, and do it fast.

Cool Edit 2000 and Sound Forge 5 come with unlimited Undo levels. Cool Edit was also quick at opening and saving files. However, it took more than a minute to resample a Wave file. Opening a file in Sound Forge took an unusually long time—35 seconds. Waveflow took 11 seconds to open a file. But it was the fastest in the resampling test, where it managed to complete it in just 12 seconds on the 51 MB file.

Value

Most of these software are Internet based; you have to purchase the software (or download a demo version) from the company's Web site. If you are looking for software that offers you average features, nothing really fancy, at a low price then Goldwave and Waveflow are good choices. If you want loads of features and have high-end audio editing on your mind then Sound Forge 5 and Cool Edit 2000 are options that can be considered by the beginner and the seasoned user as well. These also offer you good support, amazing plugins that allow you to add special effects to your audio file (such as expanding the stereo field or bending the pitch on a song) and make for effortless audio editing. But the winner is definitely **Sound Forge 5** given its advanced editing capabilities and features that make your audio editing task a pleasure.

MIDI software

The second categorisation of products in this comparison consisted of a variety of audio editing software whose core competency is in handling and sequencing MIDI software. MIDI is an acronym for Musical Instrument Digital Interface. This is a format that stores information on the basis of the tones and sounds of various musical and percussion instruments. These are actually sampled sounds. What MIDI does is send information regarding the pitch, duration and other such parameters of a note to an instrument that can play these instructions. As MIDI tracks are sequences of note instructions, the size of a MIDI file is small. Using this format, musical instruments can also interact with each other. Software called sequencers allow you to record sounds from musical instruments such as synthesisers and keyboards and edit it on a computer.

Features

Nowadays, MIDI software for home users



Wavelab 3: Offers good editing tools